What do people mean by ‘agent’?

A GenAI tip from the Eden Centre and Digital Skills Lab, LSE. This is a text version of the video, for anyone who cannot watch it.

About this document

The video is 1 minute 50 seconds long and is narrated by Steven Williams. Captions are available. This document gives the narration word for word, as it appears in the captions, then the key words and labels shown on screen, then a description of what you see. It follows the video in order, with approximate timings.

In each section, “Narration” gives the words spoken, “On screen” gives the words shown, and “What you see” describes the pictures and movement. There is no music or other sound apart from the narration.

The video is built around the tip’s square card: pale blue paper with a red rule, the headline, and a white panel comparing a chat with an agent. The camera zooms into the white panel, and everything is explained there, using the card’s simple icons with dark navy outlines. The chatbot is always shown in blue. A short label in typewriter-style text in the top-left corner names each scene, and a ladder on the left side of the screen builds up a rung at a time, one for each kind of agent.

There is also a vertical version of the video for phones. It has the same narration, timings and captions, with each layout stacked from top to bottom instead of side by side. For example, the ladder sits at the top of the screen with each rung’s details below it, and the four steps in section 8 form a numbered list instead of a row.

If you find any problems with this document or the video, please contact Steven Williams at s.williams10@lse.ac.uk.

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1. The card, and a ladder of definitions

0:00 to 0:07

Narration

What do people mean by ‘agent’? ‘Agent’ means different things depending on who’s talking.

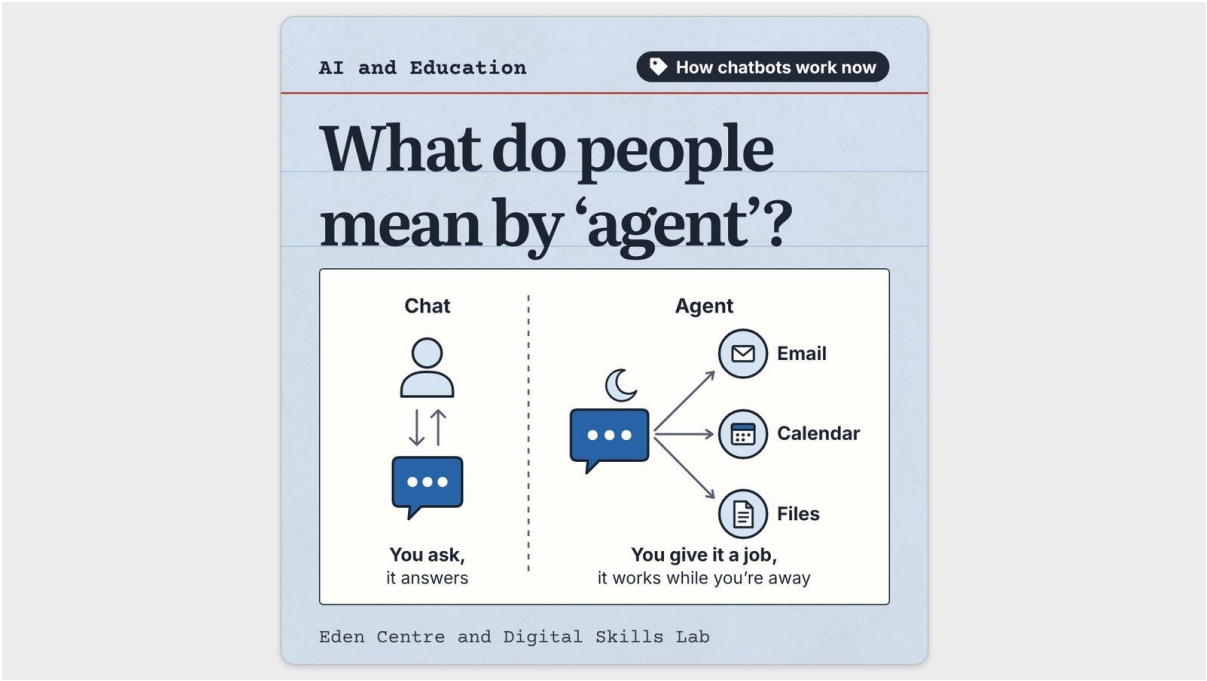
On screen

- The card: the header “AI and Education”, a tag reading “How chatbots work now”, and the headline “What do people mean by ‘agent’?”
- In the card’s white panel, on the left: “Chat”, “You ask, it answers”
- On the right: “Agent”, “Email”, “Calendar”, “Files”, “You give it a job, it works while you’re away”
- At the bottom of the card: “Eden Centre and Digital Skills Lab”
- Scene label: “Who’s talking?”
- Above the ladder: the word ‘Agent’, in quotation marks

What you see

The square tip card sits on a light grey background. It has pale blue paper with a fine fibre texture and a red rule under the header. In the white panel, the Chat side shows a person above two arrows, one pointing down and one up, and a blue speech bubble below. A dashed line separates it from the Agent side, where a blue speech bubble with a crescent moon above it sends three arrows to circles holding an envelope, a calendar and a document.

After the title is spoken, the camera zooms slowly into the white panel until it fills the screen, leaving a narrow margin of the card’s paper all round. The card’s own content fades away. An empty ladder appears on the left: two thick, pale blue rails with three blank rungs between them, and the heading ‘Agent’ above.



The tip card, as the video opens and closes.

2. Custom chatbots

0:07 to 0:14

Narration

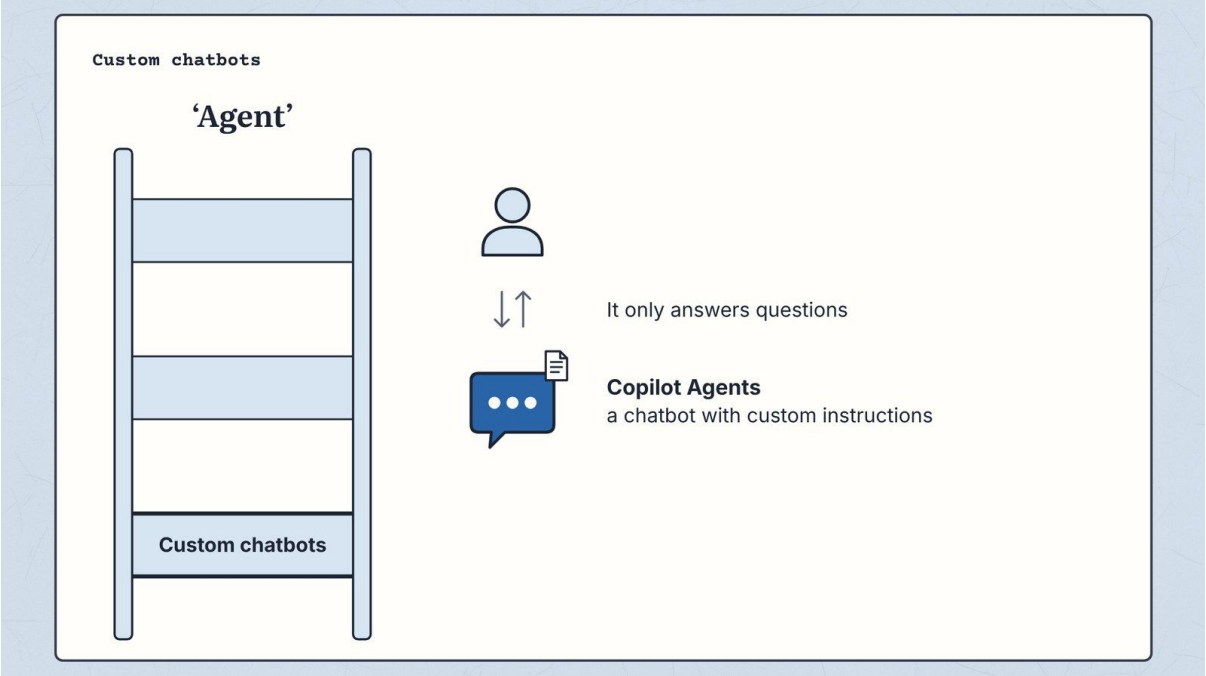
Microsoft calls chatbots with custom instructions ‘Copilot Agents’, even when they only answer questions.

On screen

- Scene label and bottom rung: “Custom chatbots”
- “Copilot Agents”, “a chatbot with custom instructions”
- “It only answers questions”
- “Similar to a Claude Project”

What you see

The bottom rung of the ladder is labelled “Custom chatbots”, and its outline thickens to show it is the one being explained. To the right, a blue speech bubble appears with a small instruction sheet clipped to its corner, labelled “Copilot Agents: a chatbot with custom instructions”. Above it, a person and a pair of arrows appear, one pointing down and one up, labelled “It only answers questions”. A small grey note follows underneath.



The bottom rung: custom chatbots.

3. Coding agents

0:14 to 0:23

Narration

When people talk about coding agents, they often mean a definition associated with Anthropic – models using tools in a loop towards a goal.

On screen

- Scene label and middle rung: “Coding agents”
- “‘models using tools in a loop’ – Anthropic”
- “Web search”, “Code”, “Files”

What you see

The bottom rung’s label turns grey and its outline returns to normal. The middle rung is labelled “Coding agents” and its outline thickens. To the right, a blue speech bubble appears, with the quotation above it. Three circles appear round the bubble: a magnifying glass labelled “Web search” at the top, code brackets labelled “Code” at the lower right and a document labelled “Files” at the lower left. Grey arrows then trace a loop clockwise, from one tool to the next and back round to the first.

4. Normal chats now

0:23 to 0:35

Narration

But normal Claude and Copilot chats now work in a similar way, which is one reason why token usage for those products is much higher than it used to be. So as a general definition, this may be out of date.

On screen

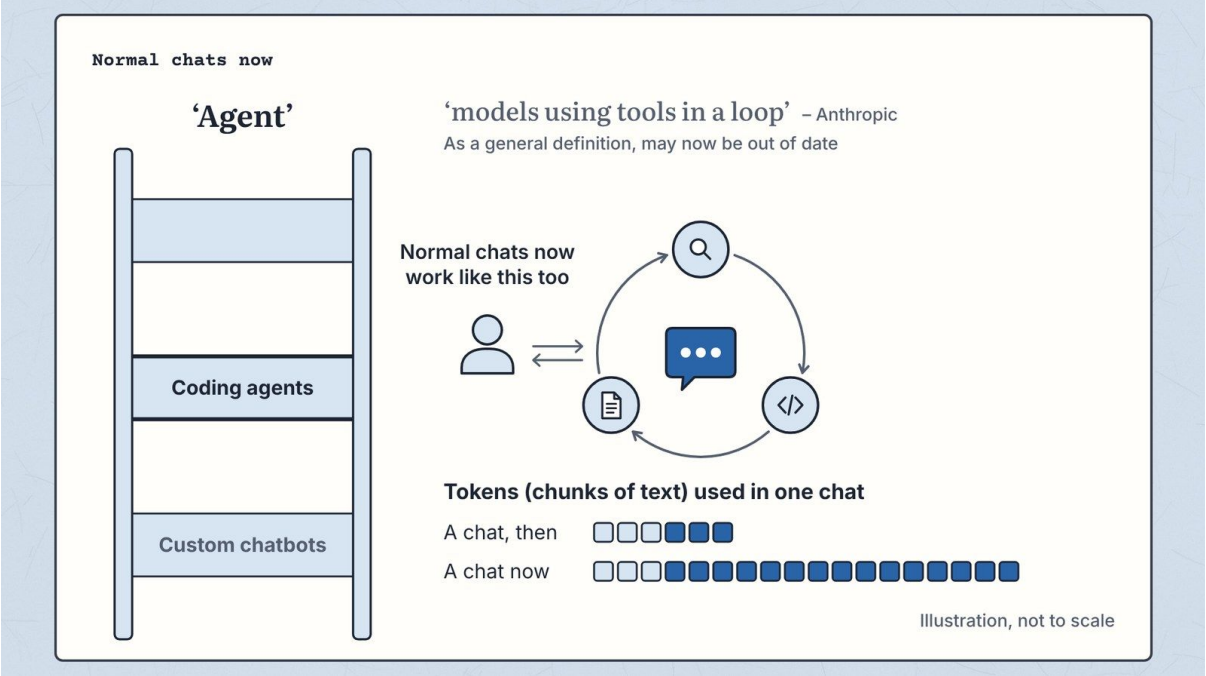
- Scene label: “Normal chats now”
- “Normal chats now work like this too”
- “Tokens (chunks of text) used in one chat”
- “A chat, then”, “A chat now”
- “Illustration, not to scale”
- “As a general definition, may now be out of date”

What you see

The tool labels fade and the quotation turns grey. A person appears to the left of the loop, joined to it by a pair of arrows pointing both ways, labelled “Normal chats now work like this too”.

Below the loop, two rows of small square tiles appear under the heading about tokens. Pale tiles stand for what you type, and blue tiles for what the chatbot produces. The first row, “A chat, then”, is short: three pale tiles and three blue tiles, a question and its answer. The second row, “A chat now”, starts with the same three pale tiles.

The loop’s arrows then light up in dark navy, one after another, three times round. Each time round, four more blue tiles drop into the second row. Three final blue tiles follow, so the second row ends up three times as long as the first: 18 tiles compared with six. A small grey note says the tiles are an illustration, not to scale. A second grey note appears under the quotation.



The middle rung: normal chats now work in a loop too, and use far more tokens.

5. Always-on agents

0:35 to 0:50

Narration

New products such as Meta's Muse and OpenAI's Dots are popularising a new definition. This kind of agent is a chatbot you give an ongoing job, and then it works in the background and takes action on your behalf. For example, buying something.

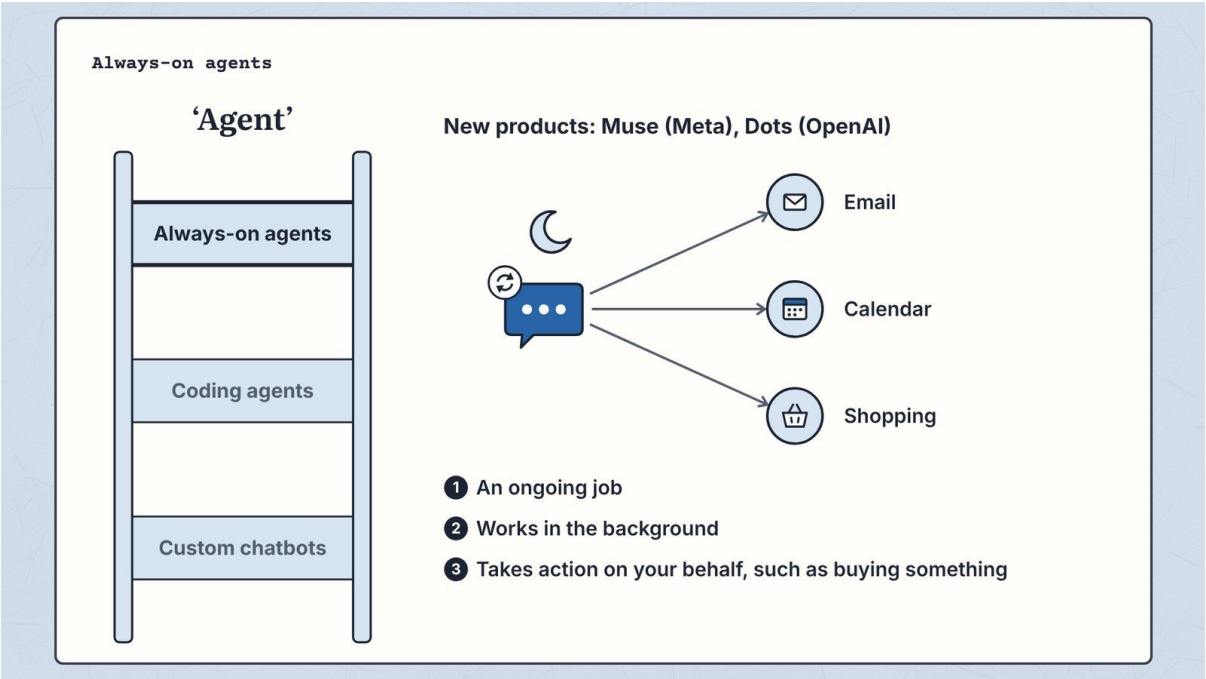
On screen

- Scene label and top rung: "Always-on agents"
- "New products: Muse (Meta), Dots (OpenAI)"
- "Email", "Calendar", "Shopping"
- A numbered list: "1 An ongoing job", "2 Works in the background", "3 Takes action on your behalf, such as buying something"

What you see

The loop and tiles fade, the middle rung's label turns grey, and the top rung is labelled "Always-on agents" and outlined. The heading naming the new products appears to the right.

A blue speech bubble appears with a small badge on its corner showing two curved arrows chasing each other round, a repeat symbol, as the first item of a numbered list appears below. A crescent moon rises above the bubble as the second item appears beneath the first. Then three arrows run out from the bubble to circles holding an envelope, a calendar and a shopping basket, as the third item appears beneath the second.



The top rung: always-on agents.

6. Why it matters

0:50 to 1:06

Narration

Why it matters. Understanding that there are different definitions can help you critically assess how the term is being used. Up this ladder, autonomy increases and so do the cognitive and security risks. What role, if any, could each type of agent have in your discipline?

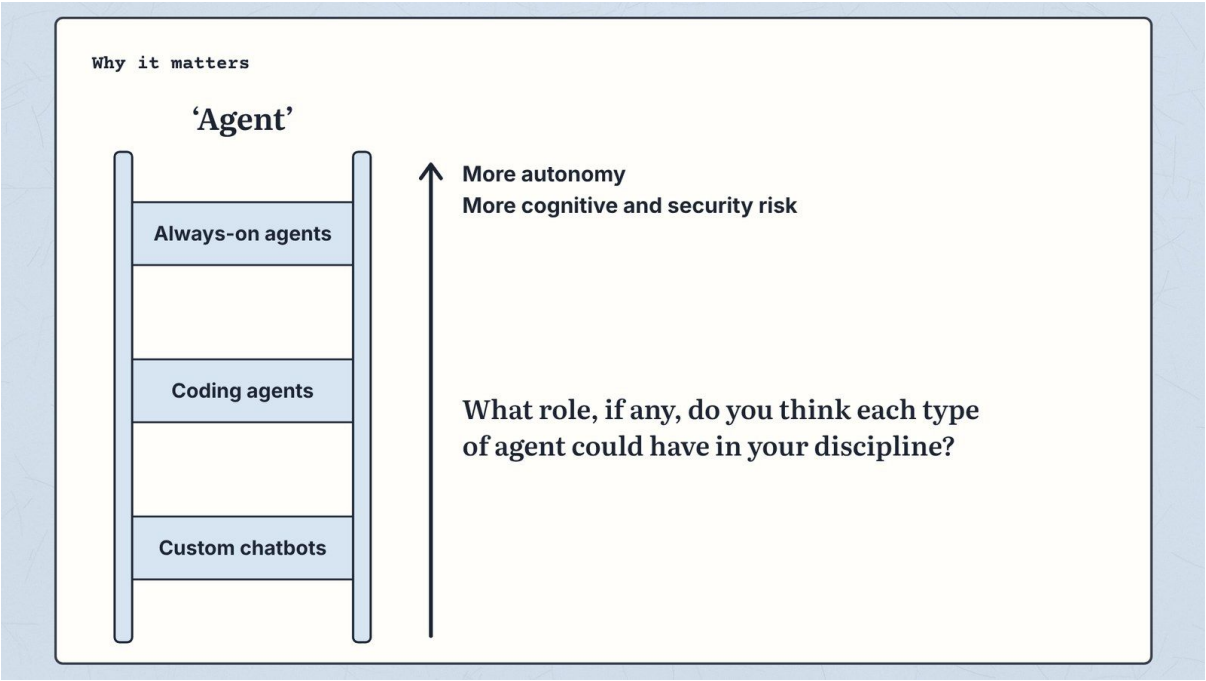
On screen

- Scene label: “Why it matters”
- “More autonomy”
- “More cognitive and security risk”
- “What role, if any, do you think each type of agent could have in your discipline?”

What you see

The details clear and the whole ladder holds, with all three labels in dark text: Custom chatbots at the bottom, Coding agents in the middle and Always-on agents at the top. As the narration mentions different definitions, all three rungs’ outlines thicken together, then return to normal.

A long arrow grows up beside the ladder, from the bottom rung to above the top one, labelled “More autonomy”. A second label joins it: “More cognitive and security risk”. The question appears below the labels, in larger serif text.



The full ladder, with the question for viewers.

7. Try this: the nearest thing at LSE

1:06 to 1:22

Narration

Try this. LSE doesn't currently have a licence for anything truly agentic, as most people now understand the term. The nearest thing is a scheduled prompt in Copilot, though it can't really act for you, and you should be aware that students don't have access to this feature.

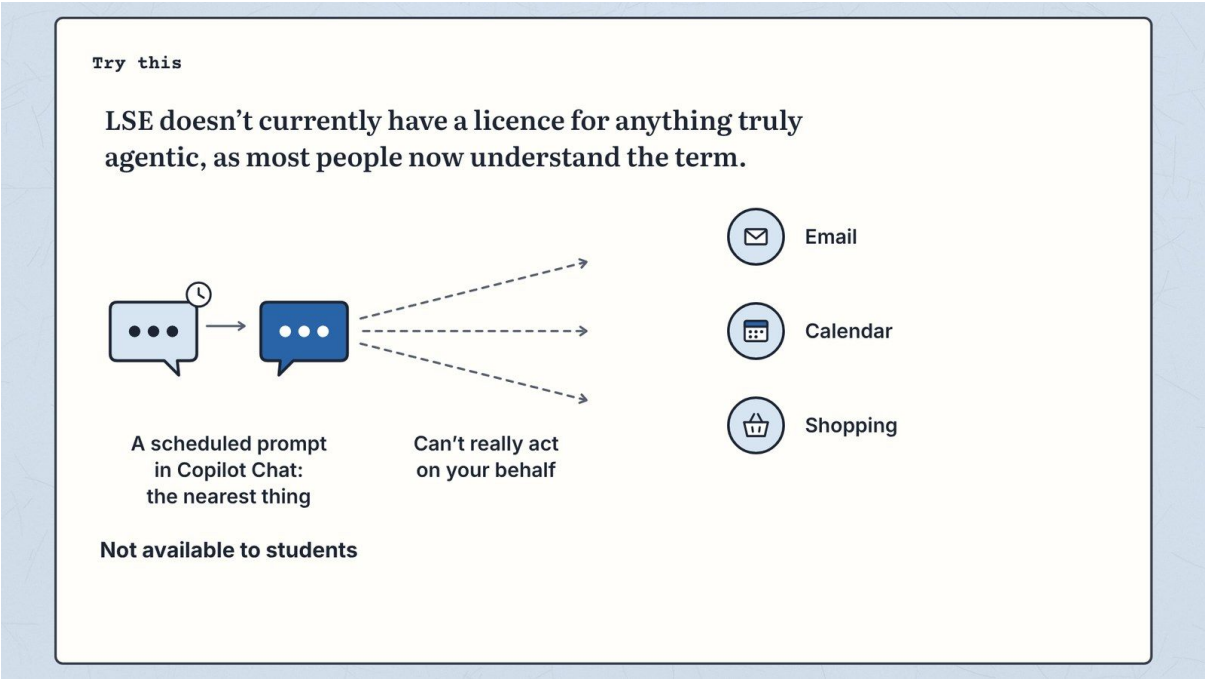
On screen

- Scene label: "Try this"
- "LSE doesn't currently have a licence for anything truly agentic, as most people now understand the term."
- "A scheduled prompt in Copilot Chat: the nearest thing"
- "Can't really act on your behalf"
- "Email", "Calendar", "Shopping"
- "Not available to students"

What you see

The ladder fades and the sentence about LSE's licence appears at the top in larger serif text. Below it, on the left, a pale speech bubble with a small clock badge, standing for your scheduled prompt, points with a short arrow to a blue speech bubble, Copilot's reply. The label appears beneath them.

Three dashed arrows reach out to the right from the blue bubble but stop well short of three circles holding an envelope, a calendar and a shopping basket. "Can't really act on your behalf" appears beneath the arrows. Finally, "Not available to students" appears beneath the label for the scheduled prompt.



Scheduled prompts: the nearest thing LSE has.

8. Try this: scheduling a prompt

1:22 to 1:44

Narration

Send Copilot a prompt, then hover over it. Select Schedule this prompt and choose how often. For example, you could ask it to check a web page you look after once a week for anything out of date, or to search for the last week's news on a topic you follow and list up to five items.

On screen

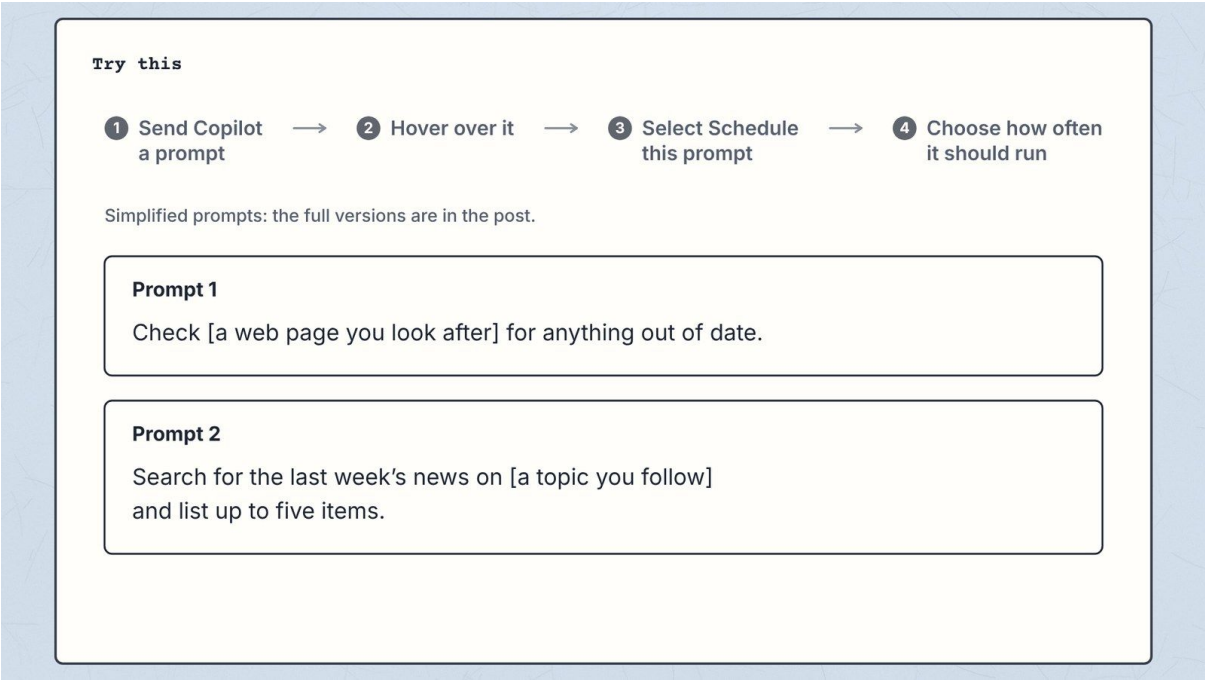
- Four numbered steps: "1 Send Copilot a prompt", "2 Hover over it", "3 Select Schedule this prompt", "4 Choose how often it should run"
- "Simplified prompts: the full versions are in the post."
- "Prompt 1": "Check [a web page you look after] for anything out of date."
- "Prompt 2": "Search for the last week's news on [a topic you follow] and list up to five items."

What you see

The screen clears, and four numbered steps appear in a row across the top, one at a time as they are mentioned, joined by arrows. The steps then turn grey. The note about the simplified prompts appears, with an empty box headed "Prompt 1" below it, where a text cursor blinks slowly. The prompt's text appears in the box just after the narration describes it.

The narration then pauses for two seconds. This pause was added after recording, at about 1:34, to give time to read the first prompt. As the narration continues with "Or", a second box headed "Prompt 2" appears below the first, with a blinking cursor, and its text appears just

after the narration describes it. Both boxes stay on screen for about three seconds after the narration ends.



The two example prompts.

9. Back to the card

1:44 to 1:50

Narration

None. This part of the video is silent.

On screen

- The card, as at the start

What you see

The prompts fade, the card's own Chat and Agent layout returns in the white panel, and the camera zooms back out to the full card, framed exactly as at the start. It holds for about three seconds before the video ends.